

**59.2**
**PER CENT**
Of funds defrauded in 2020-21 were parked in public sector banks

**₹703**
**CRORE**
Funds lost in card/ internet, deposits, and cheque/ demand draft frauds

**23**
**MONTHS**
Average time lag between detection of frauds in 2020-21 and their occurrence

Source: RBI reports for 2020-21

on its part, had already informed Bidhan Chandra Rai, the district planning officer for Saran and custodian of the MPLADS account, and an FIR had been lodged in November 2020. The economic offences wing (EOW) of the Bihar police took over the case this February, making two arrests. The Maharashtra police also arrested two people. But the swindled funds are yet to be recovered.

Banibrata Biswas, BOB assistant general manager for Muzaffarpur zone, told INDIA TODAY that the scam appeared to be the handiwork of seasoned criminals. "The fraudsters chose November 3 to present the [cloned] cheque at a BOB branch in Maharashtra well aware that the Chhapra branch would be closed because of voting for assembly elections in Bihar," he said. Biswas informed that the bank has restored the duped funds in the account in accordance with the July 2017 guideline of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) that banks have to credit any amount lost in unauthorised/ negligent transactions to the account holder.

## NOT A ONE-OFF CASE

Sigriwal's case is just one of the thousands of bank frauds committed every year in India. An RBI report on banking frauds, released in December last year, recorded 7,363 cases involving over Rs 1.38 lakh crore in 2020-21—an average of 20 cases a day. It was a 15 per cent drop from the 8,703 cases of fraud (involving over Rs 1.85 lakh crore) in 2019-20. Frauds using cheques/ demand drafts declined from Rs 63 crore in 2019-20 to Rs 39 crore in 2020-21. Card and internet frauds dropped significantly, from Rs 2,445 crore (2019-20) to Rs 535 crore (2020-21). Another Rs 119 crore were siphoned off bank balance-sheets. Frauds related to foreign exchange transactions totalled to Rs 434 crore and those involving deposits Rs 129 crore. These figures, however, are only for frauds worth Rs 1 lakh and above, which means the actual sum could be much bigger.